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8.6 Answer Explanations: Reading Comprehension

The following discussion of Reading Comprehension is intended to familiarize you with the most efficient and effective approaches to the kinds of problems common to Reading Comprehension. The particular questions in this chapter are generally representative of the kinds of Reading Comprehension questions you will encounter on the GMAT exam. Remember that it is the problem-solving strategy that is important, not the specific details of a particular question.

Questions 467–508 — Difficulty: Easy

Questions 467–469 refer to the passage on page 434.

467. The primary purpose of the passage is to

A. challenge recent findings that appear to contradict earlier findings

B. present two sides of an ongoing scientific debate

C. report answers to several questions that have long puzzled researchers

D. discuss evidence that has caused a long-standing belief to be revised

E. attempt to explain a commonly misunderstood biological phenomenon

Main Idea

This question depends on understanding the passage as a whole. The passage begins by describing a long-held belief regarding humans' circadian rhythms: that the SCNs control them. It then goes on to explain that new findings have led scientists to believe that other organs and tissues may be involved in regulating the body's circadian rhythms as well.

A. The passage does not challenge the more-recent findings. Furthermore, the recent findings that the passage recounts do not contradict earlier findings; rather, when placed alongside those earlier findings, they have led scientists to reach additional conclusions.

B. The passage does not discuss a two-sided debate; no findings or conclusions are disputed by any figures in the passages.

C. There is only one question at issue in the passage: whether the SCN alone control human circadian rhythms. Furthermore, nothing in the passage suggests that researchers have been puzzled for a long time about this.

D. **Correct.** The new evidence regarding circadian rhythm–related gene activity in all the body's tissue has led scientists to revise their long-standing belief that the SCN alone control circadian rhythms.

E. The biological phenomenon of circadian rhythms is not, at least as far as the passage is concerned, misunderstood. Its causes are being investigated and refined.

The correct answer is D.

468. The passage mentions each of the following as a function regulated by the SCNs in some animals EXCEPT:

A. activity level

B. blood pressure

C. alertness

D. vision

E. temperature

Supporting Idea

This question asks about what is NOT specifically mentioned in the passage with regard to functions regulated by the SCN. Those functions, as identified in the passage, are blood pressure, body temperature, activity level, alertness, and the release of melatonin.

A. The passage includes activity level in its list of functions regulated by the SCN.

B. The passage includes blood pressure in its list of functions regulated by the SCN.

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C. The passage includes alertness in its list of functions regulated by the SCN.

D. **Correct.** While the passage does say that cells in the human retina transmit information to the SCN, there is no suggestion that the SCN reciprocally control vision.

E. The passage includes temperature in its list of functions regulated by the SCN.

The correct answer is D.

469. The author of the passage would probably agree with which of the following statements about the SCNs?

A. The SCNs are found in other organs and tissues of the body besides the hypothalamus.

B. The SCNs play a critical but not exclusive role in regulating circadian rhythms.

C. The SCNs control clock genes in a number of tissues and organs throughout the body.

D. The SCNs are a less significant factor in regulating blood pressure than scientists once believed.

E. The SCNs are less strongly affected by changes in light levels than they are by other external cues.

Application

The author of the passage states in the second paragraph, *Four critical genes governing circadian cycles have been found to be active in every tissue, however, not just in the SCNs, of flies, mice, and humans.* The author goes on in that paragraph to point out that though scientists still accept the role of SCNs in *controlling core functions*, they *now believe that circadian clocks in other organs and tissues may respond to external cues other than light . . . that recur regularly every 24 hours*. The author nowhere disputes these beliefs, and so it is reasonable to conclude that the author of the passage agrees that these beliefs are true.

A. The author states that the SCNs are nerve clusters in the hypothalamus, and nothing in the passage contradicts or undermines the supposition that they are only in the hypothalamus.

B. **Correct.** The author indicates in the second paragraph that while scientists still believe that the SCNs control core circadian function, they also believe that circadian clocks found elsewhere in the body have an effect as well. Because the author nowhere disputes these beliefs, it is reasonable to conclude that the author would agree that SCNs play a critical but not exclusive role in regulating circadian rhythms.

C. The evidence offered in the second paragraph about the activity of the clock gene in rat livers suggests that these clock genes are not under the SCNs' control. The passage does not suggest that the SCNs control any of the non-SCN controllers of circadian rhythms.

D. The author states in the second paragraph that scientists do not dispute the idea that the SCNs regulate blood pressure.

E. The first paragraph indicates that the SCNs respond to light levels; clock genes in other tissues are the ones that may respond to other external cues.

The correct answer is B.

Questions 470–472 refer to the passage on page 436.

470. The primary purpose of the passage is to

A. question the results of a study that examined the effect of service-quality guarantees in the restaurant industry

B. discuss potential advantages and disadvantages of service-quality guarantees in the restaurant industry

C. examine the conventional wisdom regarding the effect of service-quality guarantees in the restaurant industry

D. argue that only certain restaurants would benefit from the implementation of service-quality guarantees

E. consider the impact that service-quality guarantees can have on the service provided by a restaurant

Main Idea

This question depends on understanding the passage as a whole. The first paragraph describes Tucci and Talaga's findings regarding the effect of service-quality guarantees: that they have different, more positive results for higher-priced restaurants than for lower-priced ones, which could be affected negatively. The second paragraph explains that a particular benefit from service guarantees could accrue to restaurants generally.

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A. The passage does not question the results of Tucci and Talaga's study; rather, the passage appears to accept the results of the study as accurate.

B. **Correct.** The potential advantages involve the management and motivation of service staff, as well as, for higher-priced restaurants, a greater likelihood of being selected by customers over other restaurants. Potential disadvantages for lower-priced restaurants include the possibility that potential customers may believe that such restaurants are concerned about the quality of their service.

C. The passage does not indicate whether there is any conventional wisdom regarding service-quality guarantees in the restaurant industry.

D. The second paragraph of the passage suggests that restaurants in general could potentially enjoy some benefits from the implementation of service-quality guarantees. For lower-priced restaurants, these benefits could offset the possible negative effects of service-quality guarantees described in the first paragraph.

E. The second paragraph of the passage indicates an effect that service-quality guarantees could have on a restaurant's staff and the service that the staff provides, but this is only one of the subsidiary points contributing to the focus of the passage as a whole. The first is more concerned with the question of what effect these guarantees would have on whether customers choose to patronize that restaurant.

The correct answer is B.

471. It can be inferred that the author of the passage would agree with which of the following statements about the appeal of service guarantees to customers?

A. Such guarantees are likely to be somewhat more appealing to customers of restaurants than to customers of other businesses.

B. Such guarantees are likely to be more appealing to customers who know what to anticipate in terms of service.

C. Such guarantees are likely to have less appeal in situations where customers are knowledgeable about a business's product or service.

D. In situations where a high level of financial commitment is involved, a service guarantee is not likely to be very appealing.

E. In situations where customers expect a high level of customer service, a service guarantee is likely to make customers think that a business is worried about its service.

Inference

This question asks for an inference from the passage about the author's view of why and how service guarantees would appeal to customers. The question does not ask specifically about service guarantees in the context of restaurants, but rather service guarantees in general. The end of the first paragraph addresses this general question: a service guarantee may appeal most to customers in the case of activities whose quality they are less likely to know how to question.

A. The author states that a service guarantee might have greater appeal in the case of skilled activities than it would for restaurant customers.

B. According to the author, customers who know what to expect in terms of service—a group that includes restaurant customers—would likely find service guarantees less appealing.

C. **Correct.** The author makes clear that service guarantees would be less appealing to restaurant customers when they know what to expect in terms of the quality of service.

D. The passage provides some evidence that where a high level of financial commitment is involved, a service guarantee may be more rather than less appealing than in other situations. In discussing higher-priced restaurants, which require a relatively high level of financial commitment, the author states that Tucci and Talaga found evidence that a service guarantee would likely appeal to customers.

E. The author implies that customers of higher-priced restaurants expect a high level of service, certainly a level higher than that expected by customers of lower-priced restaurants. But it is at lower-priced restaurants that Tucci and Talaga found that a service guarantee makes customers think a given restaurant is concerned about its service.

The correct answer is C.

472. According to the passage, Tucci and Talaga found that service guarantees, when offered by lower-priced

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472. According to the passage, Tucci and Talaga found that service guarantees, when offered by lower-priced restaurants, can have which of the following effects?

A. Customers' developing unreasonably high expectations regarding service

B. Customers' avoiding such restaurants because they fear that the service guarantee may not be fully honored

C. Customers' interpreting the service guarantee as a sign that management is not confident about the quality of its service

D. A restaurant's becoming concerned that its service will not be assiduous enough to satisfy customers

E. A restaurant's becoming concerned that customers will be more emboldened to question the quality of the service they receive

Supporting Idea

This question requires identifying Tucci and Talaga's findings regarding service guarantees offered by lower-priced restaurants. The passage states directly that these researchers found in these situations that a guarantee could lead potential customers to think that the restaurant has concerns about its service.

A. The passage does not report that Tucci and Talaga found that service guarantees create unreasonably high expectations regarding service.

B. The passage does not report that Tucci and Talaga found that customers doubted that service guarantees would be honored.

C. **Correct.** The passage explicitly indicates that Tucci and Talaga found that potential customers of lower-priced restaurants could interpret service guarantees as indicating worries about the quality of service.

D. The passage indicates that Tucci and Talaga found that customers might think that lower-priced restaurants are offering service guarantees because they are concerned that the quality of their service is too low, but the passage does not indicate that service guarantees lead such restaurants to have concerns about the quality of their service, and in fact it may be that such guarantees could lead to improvements in service.

E. The passage indicates that service guarantees offered at lower-priced restaurants may empower customers to question the quality of service, but it does not indicate that service guarantees lead restaurants to have concerns about this.

The correct answer is C.

Questions 473–474 refer to the passage on page 438.

Main Idea Summary

The passage primarily reports some research findings regarding the extent to which farmers in certain types of rain-forest regions are likely to adopt technologies that would increase productivity and slow deforestation by reducing demand for new cropland. It begins by noting that some studies have not included the types of farming communities that are characteristic of rain-forest regions. The latter part of the passage describes some research regarding these previously omitted communities. The findings of that research provide evidence of how various factors may influence whether farmers in those communities adopt improved plant varieties and/or chemical herbicides.

473. The passage suggests that in the study mentioned in line 14, the method for gathering information about security of land tenure reflects which of the following pairs of assumptions about Tawahka society?

A. The security of a household's land tenure depends on the strength of that household's kinship ties, and the duration of a household's residence in its village is an indication of the strength of that household's kinship ties.

B. The ample availability of land makes security of land tenure unimportant, and the lack of a need for secure land tenure has made the concept of legal property rights unnecessary.

C. The strength of a household's kinship ties is a more reliable indicator of that household's receptivity to new agricultural technologies than is its quantity of nonland wealth, and the duration of a household's residence in its village is a more reliable indicator of that household's security of land tenure than is the strength of its kinship ties.

D. Security of land tenure based on kinship ties tends to make farmers more receptive to the use of improved plant varieties, and security of land tenure based on long duration of residence in a village tends to make farmers more receptive to the use of chemical herbicides.

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E. A household is more likely to be receptive to the concept of land tenure based on legal property rights if it has easy access to uncultivated land, and a household is more likely to uphold the tradition of land tenure based on kinship ties if it possesses a significant degree of nonland wealth.

Evaluation

In discussing the study, the passage notes that the strength of kinship ties is a more important indicator of land-tenure security than are legal property rights. The researchers, knowing this, measured land-tenure security by indirectly measuring the strength of kinship ties. How long a household had resided in its village was taken as an indicator of the strength of kinship ties and, indirectly, of the household's degree of land-tenure security.

A. **Correct.** This summarizes two assumptions that the passage suggests were made by the researchers.

B. The passage notes that ample availability of land is characteristic of rain-forest communities, which presumably includes the Tawahka people on whom the study focused. However, based on the information in the passage, the study did not assume that land-tenure security was unimportant in that community.

C. The passage reports that the study took a household's duration of residence in its village as a reliable indicator of the strength of the household's kinship ties. Thus, the researchers did not assume that duration of residence was a more reliable measure of land-tenure security than kinship ties.

D. The passage does not indicate that the researchers assumed this. As already stated, the researchers in effect equated a household's strength of kinship ties with its length of residence in its village. Though only the latter was directly measured, both were regarded as guarantors and indicators of land-tenure security. According to the passage, the researchers found that *longer residence correlated with more adoption of improved plant varieties but with less adoption of chemical herbicides*. This was a finding based on research data, not an assumption.

E. The passage does not attribute to the researchers an assumption that *a household is more likely to be receptive to the concept of land tenure based on legal property rights if it has easy access to uncultivated land*.

The correct answer is A.

474. According to the passage, the proposal mentioned in line 1 is aimed at preserving rain forests by encouraging farmers in rain-forest regions to do each of the following EXCEPT:

A. adopt new agricultural technologies

B. grow improved plant varieties

C. decrease their use of chemical herbicides

D. increase their productivity

E. reduce their need to clear new land for cultivation

Supporting Idea

The goal of the proposal is to help preserve rain forests by encouraging the adoption of new agricultural technologies, including use of chemical herbicides. The latter would presumably help improve crop yields on existing land, reducing the need to clear portions of rain forest to expand agricultural production.

A. The proposal aims to encourage farmers to adopt new agricultural technologies.

B. The proposal aims to encourage farmers to grow improved plant varieties.

C. **Correct.** The proposal aims to encourage farmers to adopt new agricultural technologies, such as increased use of chemical herbicides. So persuading farmers to reduce their use of chemical herbicides is not part of the proposal.

D. The proposal aims to encourage farmers to increase their productivity.

E. The proposal aims to encourage farmers to reduce their need to clear rain-forest land for cultivation.

The correct answer is C.

Questions 475–478 refer to the passage on page 440.

Main Idea Summary

The passage as a whole functions as an introduction to the notion of monetizing (i.e., putting a monetary value on)

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ecosystem functions. The passage begins by considering the argument for monetizing such functions and then considers David Pearce's claim that all ecosystems have economic value and that, by showing this, we can help overcome the illusion that conservation is relatively unprofitable. The passage concludes with Gretchen Daily's view that monetization will help inform environmental decision-making.

475. Information in the passage suggests that David Pearce would most readily endorse which of the following statements concerning monetization?

A. Monetization represents a strategy that is attractive to both environmentalists and their critics.

B. Monetization is an untested strategy, but it is increasingly being embraced by environmentalists.

C. Monetization should at present be restricted to ecological services and should only gradually be extended to such commercial endeavors as tourism and recreation.

D. Monetization can serve as a means of representing persuasively the value of environmental conservation.

E. Monetization should inform environmental decision-making processes only if it is accepted by environmentalist groups.

Inference

This question requires an understanding of David Pearce's view of monetization. According to the passage, Pearce finds the idea that conservation is unprofitable to be an illusion. He argues for showing the economic value of ecosystems in order to make progress in conserving those ecosystems.

A. The passage attributes to Gretchen Daily the view that monetization is unpopular with environmentalists. The passage gives no reason to believe that Pearce would endorse the idea that environmentalists currently find monetization attractive.

B. The passage gives no indication that monetization is increasingly being embraced by environmentalists, even if Pearce thinks it should be.

C. The passage indicates Pearce's belief that some types of tourism are also types of ecological services that have economic value and that they should be monetized.

D. **Correct.** Pearce believes that monetization quantifies the value of the services provided by ecological systems—and if that value is quantified, people are more likely to be persuaded to conserve those systems.

E. Pearce is arguing, against some environmentalists, that monetization should inform the decision-making process with regard to preserving ecosystems.

The correct answer is D.

476. Which of the following most clearly represents an example of an "ecological service" as that term is used in line 20?

A. A resort hotel located in an area noted for its natural beauty

B. A water-purifying plant that supplements natural processes with nontoxic chemicals

C. A wildlife preserve that draws many international travelers

D. A nonprofit firm that specializes in restoring previously damaged ecosystems

E. A newsletter that keeps readers informed of ecological victories and setbacks

Application

Based on the passage, *ecological services* are services provided by natural assets that have not been converted into commercial assets. Thus, any example of such an ecological service requires that the area providing it is natural.

A. The passage mentions resort hotels as an example of explicitly commercial assets. Although some hotels might be situated in ecologically valuable natural environments, any ecological services in such cases would be contributed by the natural environments, not by the hotels themselves.

B. Water purifying is an ecological service if it is supplied by *undisturbed forests and wetlands*. The word *plant* here must mean a technological installation, not a botanical organism, because it is said to supplement —not to be part of—the natural processes. Thus, it is not a natural asset and therefore does not provide an ecological service as described in the passage.

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C. **Correct.** The passage states that a wildlife preserve that creates jobs and generates income would be providing an ecological service.

D. A nonprofit firm that restores damaged ecosystems would be performing a valuable ecology-related service, but it would not itself be an example of a natural asset providing an ecological service.

E. Environmentalists and others would most likely find such a newsletter informative, but it would not be an ecological service, because it is not a service provided by a natural asset.

The correct answer is C.

477. According to the passage, Daily sees monetization as an indication of which of the following?

A. The centrality of economic interests to people's actions

B. The reluctance of the critics of environmentalism to acknowledge the importance of conservation

C. The inability of financial interests and ecological interests to reach a common ideological ground

D. The inevitability of environmental degradation

E. The inevitability of the growth of ecological services in the future

Supporting Idea

This question asks about Daily's view of monetization, and according to the passage, she sees monetization as a practice that *reflects the dominant role that economic decisions play in human behavior*.

A. **Correct.** According to the passage, Daily believes that economic interests are central to people's actions, and monetization of ecological services would take that central role realistically into account.

B. The passage gives no evidence of this. It says nothing about how the concept of monetization relates to critics of environmentalism or about what Daily's opinion regarding such a relationship might be. It is reasonable to suppose that some critics of environmentalism would oppose the move to monetize the values of ecosystem functions because they believe that many ecosystem functions do not have true monetary value. However, the passage mentions Daily's views on the topic only as they relate to environmentalists, not to critics of environmentalism.

C. This is the opposite of what, according to the passage, Daily says can be a benefit of monetization. For Daily, monetization represents a way for financial interests and ecological interests to reach a common ground; by using this common currency, both sides can make good decisions about the environment.

D. Monetization, in Daily's view, would help to prevent environmental degradation; the passage does not suggest that she regards such degradation as at all inevitable.

E. Daily does not see monetization as inevitably spurring the growth of ecological services but as more likely preventing their decline by leaving those services undisturbed.

The correct answer is A.

478. Which of the following can be inferred from the passage concerning the environmentalists mentioned in line 8?

A. They are organized in opposition to the generation of income produced by the sale of ecological services.

B. They are fewer in number but better organized and better connected to the media than their opponents.

C. They have sometimes been charged with failing to use a particular strategy in their pursuit of conservational goals.

D. They have been in the forefront of publicizing the extent of worldwide environmental degradation.

E. They define environmental progress differently and more conservatively than do other organized groups of environmentalists.

Inference

The sentence in question states that critics blame environmentalists for their failure *to address the economic issues of environmental degradation*.

A. The passage states that, in the absence of monetization, conservation can appear unprofitable. But this does not mean that the environmentalists in question are opposed to conservation generating income.

B. The passage does not address the issue of the number of environmentalists in question, the number of those opposed to them, or whether either group is better connected to the media.

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opposed to them, or whether either group is better connected to the media.

C. **Correct.** The passage indicates that critics of the environmentalists in question believe environmentalists are to blame for not using an effective economics-based strategy to promote conservation.

D. Although it may be the case that the environmentalists in question have been prominent in publicizing worldwide environmental degradation, the passage does not provide grounds for inferring that the possibility is necessarily true.

E. The passage suggests that certain critics consider environmentalists in general to be at fault for failing to address economic issues. In this respect, the passage makes no distinctions among different environmentalist groups, organized or otherwise, yet this answer choice is based on the assumption that the passage has made this distinction. Therefore, this answer choice cannot be inferred from the passage.

The correct answer is C.

Questions 479–482 refer to the passage on page 442.

Main Idea Summary

The passage provides a definition of social learning and utilizes an animal's acquisition for preferences of novel foods as an example of social learning. The focus is on the similarities and differences between how birds and other animals acquire novel foods and theorizes that avian social learning differs from that of other mammals. Several studies including Sherwin's recent studies with domestic hens are featured.

479. Which of the following best describes the main purpose of the first paragraph of the passage?

A. It explains why a particular behavior discussed in the remainder of the passage is beneficial to the animals that engage in it.

B. It introduces a concept that has been widely misunderstood among nonscientists.

C. It outlines the types of studies that have been conducted to investigate a certain animal behavior.

D. It provides information necessary to understand the nature of the phenomenon discussed in the remainder of the passage.

E. It describes a viewpoint that is called into question later in the passage.

Inference

The passage discusses how, if at all, social learning may affect the development of food preferences among avian species. The first paragraph functions to orient the reader by introducing and clarifying the concept of social learning.

A. The main purpose of the first paragraph is not to explain why social learning would benefit animals engaging in it.

B. Nothing in the passage states or implies that any concept introduced in the first paragraph has been widely misunderstood among nonscientists.

C. The first paragraph provides no information about studies that have investigated an animal behavior.

D. **Correct.** The information in the first paragraph is needed for readers to understand the main topic of discussion in the passage.

E. The first paragraph consists of factual assertions about social learning but contains no viewpoint that the passage provides reason to reject.

The correct answer is D.

480. According to the passage, Sherwin's research team speculated the social learning of unpalatability within a particular species might be discouraged if the animals

A. did not suffer serious effects from any noxious or toxic foods they ingested

B. consumed food in small quantities throughout the day rather than in a few large feedings

C. had an unusually large variety of foods available to them

D. interacted after feeding as well as during feeding

E. did not show signs of illness until considerable time had passed following the ingestion of noxious or toxic food

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food

Supporting Idea

Sherwin's research is discussed in the final paragraph of the passage. Sherwin's research team speculated about conditions that could have minimized any increase in survival value derivable from social learning of unpalatability. This could occur if little or no harm resulted from ingesting noxious or toxic food.

A. **Correct.** If noxious or toxic foods were consumed by animals without causing death or significant illness, observer animals might not learn to avoid those foods.

B. Animals' consumption of only a small quantity of a toxic or noxious food at one time is not mentioned as a condition that Sherwin's research team speculated could impede social learning of the food's unpalatability.

C. The passage does not mention availability of a large variety of foods as a condition that Sherwin's team speculated could impede social learning about the unpalatability of a noxious or toxic food.

D. The passage does not mention interaction after feeding as a condition that Sherwin's team speculated could impede social learning about the unpalatability of a noxious or toxic food.

E. A long time-lapse after eating an unpalatable food before illness appeared is not mentioned in the passage as a condition that Sherwin's team speculated could impede social learning about the unpalatability of the food.

The correct answer is A.

481. According to the passage, which of the following is true of the experiments on domestic hens conducted by Sherwin's research team?

A. Only a small number of observer hens appeared to learn to avoid food that was demonstrated by other hens to be noxious.

B. Observer hens ingested food preferentially only after numerous instances of witnessing demonstrator hens preferentially ingest that type of food.

C. Observer hens appeared unable to recognize when demonstrator hens found a particular food especially palatable.

D. Demonstrator hens reacted adversely to ingesting certain novel foods.

E. Demonstrator hens altered their behavior less obviously in response to noxious foods than in response to highly palatable foods.

Evaluation

The passage describes experiments on social learning in domestic hens done by Sherwin's research team. We are asked to select a statement that accurately characterizes the experiments based on the information given. Two different kinds of experiments were conducted: one kind in which a demonstrator tried eating a new food and reacted negatively, and another kind in which the demonstrator reacted favorably.

A. The passage suggests that no evidence was found of observer hens avoiding a novel food that a demonstrator hen had found unpalatable.

B. Nothing in the passage indicates that before developing a preference for a particular type of food, observer hens needed to see several instances of a demonstrator hen preferring food of that type.

C. Nothing in the passage indicates that observer hens were unable to interpret the aversive responses of demonstrator hens to a food as indicating unpalatability.

D. **Correct.** The passage's third paragraph indicates that there were some instances in which demonstrator hens "reacted with obvious disgust" to a novel food that was noxious or toxic.

E. The passage's description of the Sherwin experiments makes clear that demonstrator hens showed obvious aversion to noxious or toxic foods. However, the passage neither states nor implies any comparison of the obviousness of such responses with that of responses to highly palatable foods.

The correct answer is D.

482.

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